A BEGINNER'S COURSE · NO EXPERIENCE NEEDED

The X algorithm, explained from zero

If you've never thought about how X (Twitter) decides what people see, start here. No jargon, no hacks — just how the feed actually works, taught one simple idea at a time, with a picture on every page.

WHAT YOU'LL UNDERSTAND BY THE END

- → Why X needs an "algorithm" at all — and what it's really doing
- → The two steps every post goes through: getting *found*, then getting *ranked*
- → The one surprising fact that changes how you'd post forever
- → The myths to ignore — and a simple plan for your first two weeks

HOW TO TAKE THIS COURSE

Nine short lessons. Read in order — each one builds on the last. ~20 minutes total. You don't need to post anything yet; just understand the machine first.

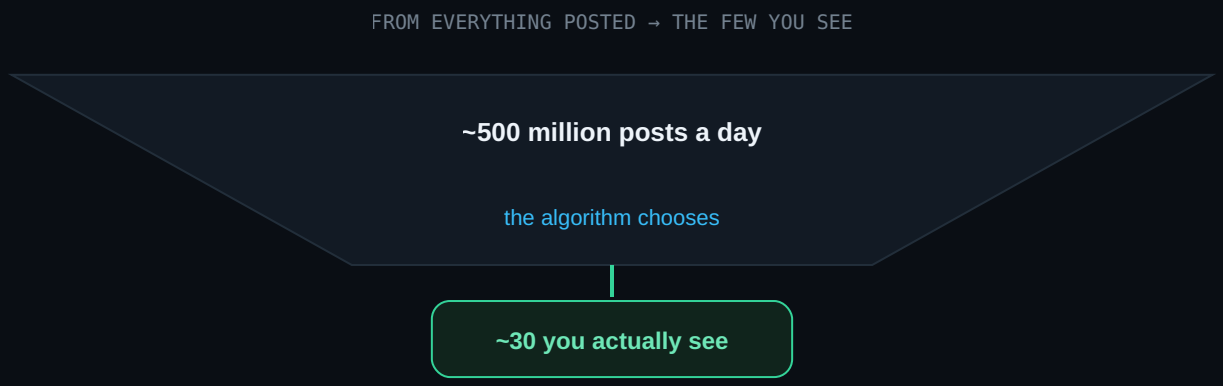
Based on the algorithm X open-sourced (github.com/xai-org/x-algorithm) and its 2023 release. Some exact figures are X's published 2023 numbers. Not affiliated with X.

LESSON 1 · THE BIG PICTURE

What is "the algorithm," really?

Every day, people post around **500 million** things on X. You'll see maybe **30** of them in a sitting. So something has to choose which 30. That "something" is the algorithm.

It isn't a person, and it isn't random. It's a computer program with one job: out of everything posted, pick the handful it thinks *you* will find interesting enough to stick around for. That's it. Everything else in this course is just *how* it guesses.



The whole game is a filter: millions in, a few out — chosen for you specifically.

REMEMBER THIS

The algorithm is just a chooser. Its only goal is to show each person the posts they're most likely to enjoy and engage with.

LESSON 2 · THE MOST IMPORTANT IDEA

It's personal — there's no "good post"

Here's the thing most people get wrong: the algorithm doesn't decide if your post is "good" in general. It guesses, for *each individual person*, whether *they* will like it.

The exact same post can fly for one person's followers and flop for another's. There is no universal score, because there's no universal viewer. This is why "growth hacks" that promise one magic trick don't work — there's no single lever, because every person's feed is judged separately.

Shown to Maya

She replies to cooking posts all day. Your recipe thread? The algorithm bets she'll love it → it shows her.

Hidden from Sam

He only engages with sports. Same recipe thread → the algorithm bets he'll scroll past → it doesn't bother.

THINK OF IT LIKE

A personal radio station for every user. It learns each person's taste from what they tune into, and only plays them more of what they actually listen to.

REMEMBER THIS

The algorithm scores your post *against each viewer*, using what that person has engaged with before. Your job isn't to please "the algorithm" — it's to make something a specific kind of person genuinely wants.

LESSON 3 · HOW IT WORKS, STEP BY STEP

The two steps: find, then rank

When you open X, the algorithm does two jobs in under two seconds.

Step 1 — Find. Out of millions of posts, it grabs a few thousand that *might* interest you: some from people you follow, and some from strangers it thinks match your taste.
Step 2 — Rank. It puts those in order, best guess on top, and shows you the winners.



Find narrows the ocean to a bucket; Rank decides the order in the bucket.

REMEMBER THIS

Two different things have to go right: your post has to get *found* (Lesson 4), and then *ranked* highly (Lessons 5–6). Most people only think about one of them.

LESSON 4 · GETTING FOUND

How strangers discover you

Getting shown to people who already follow you is easy. The real growth comes from *strangers* — and that's where "Find" matters.

To do it, X effectively sorts everyone into interest groups, and sorts every post by topic too. When you post about, say, cooking, it shows your post to the "cooking" crowd — people who reliably engage with cooking. The clearer your topic, the easier you are to place. If your account is a jumble of cooking, crypto, and hot takes, the algorithm doesn't know which room to put you in — so it shows you to no one new.

YOUR CLEAR, ON-TOPIC POST LANDS IN THE RIGHT CROWD



Be clearly about one thing, and the algorithm knows exactly who to show you to.

REMEMBER THIS

Pick one lane and stay in it. "Being about one thing" isn't branding advice — it's literally how the algorithm finds new people for you.

LESSON 5 · GETTING RANKED

What the algorithm is counting

Once your post is found, how does it decide the order? It guesses what each viewer will *do* with it, and adds up the answers.

For every post, it predicts the chance you'll do each of these — and some are good, some are bad:

Good signals (push it up)

Reply · reply that you answer · open the author's profile · click in and read a while · repost · like.

Bad signals (push it down)

"Show less often" · mute · block · report. These tell X "stop showing me this."

So far this might sound obvious — likes and replies good, blocks bad. But here's the part almost nobody knows, and it's the most useful thing in this course. Turn the page.

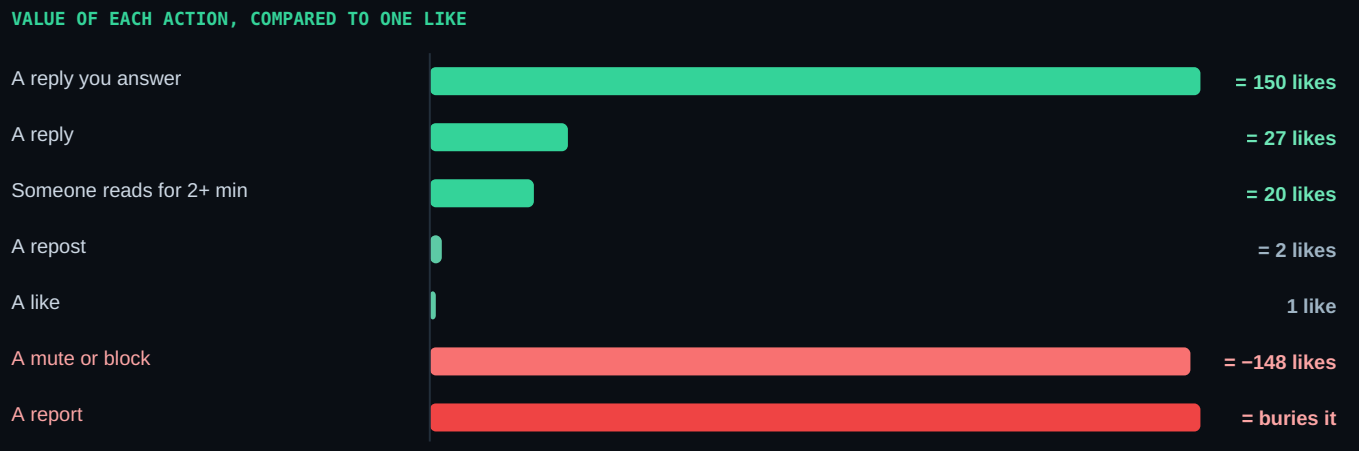
REMEMBER THIS

The algorithm isn't counting "engagement" as one blob. It predicts *specific* actions — and as you're about to see, they are *wildly* unequal.

LESSON 6 · THE BIG SECRET

Not all actions are worth the same

A like is the smallest unit of approval. Everything else is worth far, far more. Here's roughly what each action is worth, compared to a single like:



Based on X's published 2023 weights. The exact numbers change; the huge gaps don't.

Read that again. A reply you answer can be worth around **150 likes**. A like is worth… one like. And one block from the wrong person can wipe out the value of ~150 likes of work.

REMEMBER THIS — THIS IS THE WHOLE GAME

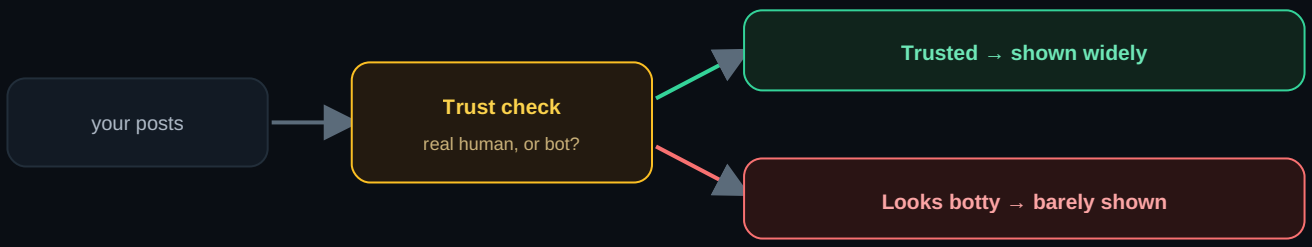
Chase **conversation, not applause**. A post that gets 12 real replies you answer beats a post that gets 1,000 silent likes. Write things people *reply* to — then reply back.

LESSON 7 · THE HIDDEN GATE

It also judges your whole account

Even a great post can go nowhere if the algorithm doesn't trust the *account* behind it. Before it shows your stuff widely, it quietly asks: "is this a real, trusted human — or a spammy bot?"

It looks at simple signals: do a sane number of real people follow you (versus you following thousands and almost nobody following back)? Is your account established, not brand-new? Do you behave like a person, not a script posting copy-paste every few minutes? Trust builds slowly and gets passed to you when credible accounts engage with you.



REMEMBER THIS

Look like a real, trusted human: don't mass-follow then unfollow, don't buy followers, don't spam. No clever post fixes a low-trust account — fix the account first.

LESSON 8 · DON'T WASTE YOUR TIME

Myths to ignore

A lot of "Twitter advice" is years out of date or never true. X rebuilt its system and threw these out — so don't spend a second on them:

- ✗ "Post at the perfect time of day."
  Your post doesn't race other posts for a slot. Post when you can stick around to reply.
- ✗ "Stuff your post with hashtags."
  Ignored at best; looks spammy at worst.
- ✗ "Follow lots of people so they follow back."
  Hurts the trust check, and you'll have to unfollow later anyway.
- ✗ "Buy followers / use engagement pods."
  Fake signals teach the algorithm the wrong audience for you.
- ✗ "Post 30 times a day to win."
  It deliberately spaces out one account's posts — 1–3 strong posts beat 30 weak ones.

REMEMBER THIS

If a tip is a one-time "trick," be suspicious. The system is built to reward genuine, consistent behaviour and to ignore mechanical shortcuts.

LESSON 9 · PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Your first two weeks

You now understand the machine. Here's the smallest plan that uses everything you learned — no hacks, just the fundamentals.

- ✓ Pick **one topic** you can talk about for months.
  Lesson 4 — so the algorithm knows who to show you to.
- ✓ Post **once a day**, and end posts with something real to reply to.
  Lesson 6 — manufacture conversation, not likes.
- ✓ When people reply, **reply back** — especially in the first hour.
  Lesson 6 — the single most valuable action.
- ✓ Reply to **5 bigger accounts** in your topic every day.
  Lesson 7 — trust rubs off, and people discover you.
- ✓ Keep your account **clean & human**: sane follow ratio, no spammy patterns.
  Lesson 7 — pass the trust check.
- ✓ **Ignore** best-time charts, hashtags, and follower-count games.
  Lesson 8 — they do nothing.

THE ONE SENTENCE TO KEEP

Be clearly about one thing, post things people *have* to reply to, reply back, and act like a real human. Do that for a few months and the algorithm starts working *for* you.

REFERENCE · PLAIN-ENGLISH GLOSSARY

Words you'll hear

The For You feed — the main, algorithm-chosen feed (as opposed to "Following", which is just people you follow, newest first).

Impressions — how many times your post appeared on someone's screen.

Reach — how many different people saw it.

In-network — posts from accounts you follow. **Out-of-network** — posts from strangers the algorithm picked for you (this is where new growth comes from).

Dwell time — how long someone spends looking at your post. Longer = a good sign.

Ratio (follower / following) — how many follow you versus how many you follow. Following far more than follow you looks low-trust.

Reply-back — when someone replies and you reply to them. The most valuable thing that can happen to a post.

De-amplified — still allowed, but quietly shown to fewer people (often for safety/spam reasons), no matter how good the post is.

That's the course. Everything here is drawn from the algorithm X open-sourced; the exact scoring numbers are X's published 2023 figures and shift over time, but the ideas — personal scoring, find-then-rank, conversation over likes, trusted accounts — are the durable parts. Not affiliated with X or xAI.